

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN THE FAROE ISLANDS

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Concern for the environment in the Faroe Islands turns almost entirely on the sea, and on an economy built upon it. This is a small, remote North Atlantic archipelago — eighteen steep, green, wind-scoured islands of deep fjords, high sea-cliffs, and vast seabird colonies, ringed by rich cold waters, with fewer than fifty thousand people and a strong, ancient, transparent democracy, self-governing within the Kingdom of Denmark. Its people have lived from the ocean for centuries, and its modern prosperity rests overwhelmingly on fishing and, above all, on the industrial farming of salmon that now provides more than two-fifths of the islands' exports. That dependence means almost every environmental question here is also an economic one. There is no single landmark community victory to point to, and the hardest questions — the salmon industry's footprint, the seabird declines, the wild fisheries, the contested whale hunt — are bound up with livelihoods and identity. But the levers run through an open, democratic, rule-of-law society reckoning honestly with how to keep the sea it lives from healthy, and they are strong.

A community in the Faroe Islands works with genuinely strong tools, in an open, rule-of-law democracy. The distinctive one is the **aquaculture regulation, monitoring, and sustainability standards**: the salmon industry that is the islands' economic backbone can be scrutinised and reformed through the licences, the environmental monitoring, and the standards that govern it. Infrastructure and coastal projects must reckon with **environmental assessment and planning**; protest, petition, and litigation are lawful in this open society. The seabird colonies and the sea can be defended through **habitat protection and marine designations**. The wild fisheries are governed by **fisheries science and management** — the quotas and science-based limits a case can invoke. And behind them all stand the **open democracy, the rule of law, the free press, and the community**: the parliament, the ministries, the aquaculture and veterinary regulators, the fisheries and marine research institutions, and the courts. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. The salmon industry is the economic foundation, so its reform must reckon with livelihoods. The seabird declines are driven largely by a warming ocean beyond any local fix. The wild fisheries are the historic basis of life here. The pilot-whale hunt is a deeply held tradition on which reasonable people, Faroese and outsiders, genuinely disagree. And the economy simply is the sea. So the honest work is the reform of how the islands use their sea — an aquaculture operation better sited or regulated, a habitat protected, a fishery kept within science-based limits, an infrastructure project properly assessed — through the regulation, the science, and the open democratic process, reckoning honestly with the livelihoods the sea sustains.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You win here not by fighting the sea-based economy but by reforming how the islands use their sea, in a democracy that genuinely responds. Scrutinise the salmon industry through its regulation, monitoring, and standards; defend the seabirds and the sea through habitat protection and marine measures; hold the wild fisheries to science-based limits; assess the infrastructure; and use the open parliament, courts, press, and community — always reckoning honestly with the livelihoods the sea sustains.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

The Faroes are an open, hopeful setting — a strong democracy with genuine institutions. But honesty about the harder truths is the first discipline. Almost every environmental question is also economic: the salmon industry is the backbone, the fisheries the historic basis of life, and the economy is the sea itself, so reform must reckon with livelihoods. The seabird declines are largely climatic, beyond any local fix. And the whale hunt is a genuinely contested tradition. So aim at the winnable — an operation better regulated, a habitat protected, a fishery kept within limits — through the regulation, the science, and the open democratic process.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

A Faroese project runs through a small, open, sea-governing democracy. The **government and the ministries of fisheries, environment, and industry** decide the licences, the quotas, and the rules, answerable to the parliament and the public. The **aquaculture and veterinary regulators, the fisheries and marine research institutions, and the environmental bodies** hold the monitoring, the science, and the standards — real levers. And the **parliament, the open democratic process, the free press, and the courts** offer genuine avenues in one of the world's more transparent societies. Map who decides a project's fate before spending a week on it.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

An aquaculture operation needs a licence and must meet the monitoring and sustainability standards; an infrastructure or coastal project needs assessment and planning; a fishery is governed by science-based quotas. Each is a point of entry: the licence and standards for the salmon farm, the assessment for the infrastructure, the science and quotas for the fishery. Because the institutions are open and genuine, a documented case engaged early — at the licence, the assessment, or the quota-setting — can shape the outcome.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the licence: what an aquaculture operation is permitted, and whether it meets the monitoring and sustainability standards. Follow the assessment: what an infrastructure project must satisfy. Follow the science: what the fisheries and marine research shows, and what limits it sets. The leverage lies in the aquaculture regulation, the assessment, the habitat protections, and the fisheries science.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

The Faroes have real watchers: the aquaculture and veterinary regulators, the fisheries and marine research institutions, the environmental bodies, the parliament, the free press, and the courts. In a small, transparent democracy, these institutions genuinely function, and a case is built to engage them — and, where they fall short of their own standards, to hold them to account.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Reform in the Faroes is genuinely achievable, in an open democracy with strong institutions, though it must reckon with the sea-based economy. The single most decisive move is **grounding the case in the regulation and the science** — the aquaculture standards, the fisheries limits, the assessment — because the Faroese institutions respond to documented, science-based cases, and because a reform framed

around the health of the sea the islands live from speaks to the whole society's interest. The aquaculture regulation is the distinctive lever; the science the foundation; the open democratic channels genuinely work. What the tools deliver is real reform — an operation better regulated or sited, a habitat protected, a fishery kept within limits, an infrastructure project improved — reckoning honestly with the livelihoods at stake.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the aquaculture footprint, the habitat or seabird colony at risk, the fishery pressure, the infrastructure impact. **What governs it?** — the aquaculture licence and standards, the assessment, the fisheries science. **What does the science show?** — the monitoring and research data. **Who is the coalition?** — the community, the scientists, the press, the wider public. **What is the livelihood dimension?** — how reform reckons with the sea-based economy. Pick the fight where the regulation or the science offers the clearest handle and the reform speaks to the health of the sea.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

Build the case in layers. **Layer one: the harm** — the aquaculture impact, the habitat or seabird pressure, the fishery or infrastructure effect, documented with the monitoring and science. **Layer two: the standard** — the aquaculture licence and sustainability standards, the assessment requirements, the fisheries limits the harm breaches or strains. **Layer three: the coalition and the livelihood** — the scientists, community, and press to engage, and an honest reckoning with the economic dimension, so the reform is credible. A case grounded in the regulation and the science, framed around the sea the islands live from, is one the Faroese institutions take seriously.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm record**: the aquaculture monitoring, the habitat and seabird data, the fisheries science, the infrastructure assessment. Gather the **standard record**: the aquaculture licences and sustainability standards, the assessment requirements, the fisheries quotas and limits. Gather the **coalition record**: the scientists, the community, the free press, the wider public. Gather the **livelihood record**: the economic dimension the reform must reckon with. The Faroes' transparency makes most of this genuinely obtainable.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

The Faroes' strength is a small, cohesive, open democracy. Build a coalition of the **affected community and residents**, whose stake in the sea is direct; the **scientists and marine researchers** who hold the evidence; the **fishers and industry voices** who can be reckoned with rather than only opposed; and the **free press and wider public**. Because the economy is the sea, the strongest coalition frames reform around a healthy sea that sustains livelihoods for the long term — winning the industry and fishers as partners in sustainability where possible, not only as adversaries.

STEP 4: AQUACULTURE, HABITAT & FISHERIES LEVERS — REFORMING HOW THE ISLANDS USE THE SEA

Set expectations honestly: here the levers are real and strong, in an open democracy, though every one reckons with the sea-based economy.

The Aquaculture Regulation and Standards

The distinctive lever is the **aquaculture regulation, monitoring, and sustainability standards**: the salmon industry can be scrutinised and reformed through its licences, its environmental monitoring, and the standards it must meet. Document where an operation breaches or strains them, and press for better siting, tighter regulation, or reform.

The Habitat Protection and the Assessment

The **seabird colonies and the sea** can be defended through **habitat protection and marine designations**, and infrastructure through **environmental assessment and planning**. Invoke the protections and the assessment to defend a habitat or improve a project.

The Fisheries Science and the Democracy

The **wild fisheries** are governed by **science-based management and quotas**, and the **open democracy, courts, and press** enforce it all. Pursued together — the aquaculture regulation, the habitat and assessment, and the fisheries science — through the open democratic process, these levers reform how the islands use their sea, reckoning honestly with livelihoods.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case to each audience. **For the aquaculture regulator**: here is an operation that breaches or strains the standards and monitoring. **For the environmental and habitat bodies**: here is a colony or habitat your protections cover. **For the fisheries and marine institutions**: here is a pressure the science and limits should address. **For the parliament and public**: here is a reform that keeps the sea the islands live from healthy for the long term. **For the industry and fishers**: here is a sustainable path that protects livelihoods. **The golden rule**: ground the case in the regulation and the science, frame it around a healthy sea, and reckon honestly with the livelihoods — reform, not mere opposition, is the aim.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In an open democracy with a free press, media matters. Frame the story around **the sea and its long-term health**: an ocean the islands live from, and how to keep it healthy for livelihoods and nature alike. Carry it through the Faroese press, the Nordic and international outlets, and the community's networks. A few cautions: keep it accurate and grounded in the science and regulation; reckon honestly with the economic dimension rather than dismissing it; treat genuinely contested questions, like the whale hunt, with the honesty they deserve; and let the monitoring, the science, and the standards carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message factual, grounded in the regulation and science, and honest about livelihoods.

8A — To the aquaculture regulator: identify the operation and the standards or monitoring it breaches, and request reform or better siting.

8B — To the environmental or habitat body: connect the harm to a protected colony or habitat and ask for the protection to be enforced.

8C — To the fisheries or marine institution: set out the pressure and ask the science and limits to address it.

8D — On an infrastructure project: request the environmental assessment and the improvements it should require.

8E — To a member of parliament: summarise the reform and its service to the long-term health of the sea.

8F — To the industry or fishers: propose the sustainable path that protects livelihoods.

8G — To a scientist or marine researcher: request the monitoring and evidence.

8H — To the press: offer the documented, science-based case framed around the sea, and ask for coverage.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: find the licence, standards, or science governing the harm; document it with the monitoring and research; write the one-page reform case framed around the sea. **The fastest-moving levers:** the aquaculture regulation, the habitat protections, and the fisheries science. **Emergency coalition-building:** reach the scientists, the community, and the press first; in so small a society they mobilise quickly. Throughout, ground everything in the regulation and science, and reckon honestly with livelihoods.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Even in a strong democracy the field can tilt toward the sea-based economy: an industry that is the backbone, a livelihood dimension that resists reform. Recognise it, and lean on the levers the tilt cannot escape — the aquaculture standards, the science, the habitat protections, the assessment, the open democratic process. In the Faroes these genuinely work. And accept, honestly, that reform must reckon with livelihoods, that the seabird decline is largely climatic and beyond local fix, and that some questions, like the whale hunt, are genuinely and reasonably contested.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

The Faroes are a transparent, rule-of-law democracy, so outright capture is uncommon; the more usual challenge is an industry so central that its interests weigh heavily. Where a decision is made against the science or the standards to favour an interest, respond through the open channels the Faroes genuinely provide: the regulators, the science, the parliament, the free press, the courts, and the transparency a small democracy affords. **On safety:** the Faroe Islands are a safe, rule-of-law democracy; the risks here are political and economic, not physical, so the work is open, lawful, and public — but always accurate, honest about livelihoods, and respectful of the genuinely contested questions.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The steps run in parallel. The documented harm feeds the aquaculture, habitat, and fisheries cases at once; the community, scientists, and industry organise alongside; the media carries the healthy-sea frame throughout. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, document the harm and the standard or science, and

engage the regulators; **months two to six**, press the aquaculture regulation, the habitat protections, the fisheries science, and the assessment, and build the coalition; **beyond**, secure the reform and hold it. The core discipline: grounded in the regulation and science, framed around the sea, and honest about livelihoods.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Reform in the Faroe Islands is genuinely achievable, because it is a small, open, rule-of-law democracy with strong institutions and a transparent public life. This guide has been honest that almost every environmental question here is also economic — the salmon industry is the backbone, the fisheries the historic basis of life, the economy the sea itself — so reform must reckon with livelihoods; that the seabird declines are largely climatic and beyond any local fix; and that the whale hunt is a genuinely contested tradition. But those honest truths do not make the effort futile — they define its shape. A community that grounds its case in the aquaculture regulation and standards, the habitat protections, the fisheries science, and the assessment, uses the open parliament, courts, and press, and frames its reform around a sea kept healthy for livelihoods and nature alike can genuinely improve how the islands use their sea. The odds here are favourable, the tools are strong, and the work is the honest reform of a society reckoning with the ocean it lives from.